



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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THE QUIET RESET

From protein intake to hormonal recovery, what athletes eat during the off-season often defines their **longevity.**



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For nearly 20 years, I have sat across from athletes in every possible emotional state. I have seen them at their peak after a podium finish, and I have seen them three weeks later, confused about what to eat when training volume suddenly drops. If there is one phase that quietly decides the next season, it is the off-season.

Most athletes think of the off-season as a break. I think of it as a reset.

When the competitive calendar ends, the body is not the same one that began the season. It is carrying inflammation, small tissue damage, hormonal fatigue, and often mental exhaustion. Jumping straight into indulgence or, on the other extreme, cutting calories aggressively, are both mistakes I see too often.

The first principle I follow with every athlete is this: reduce intake in proportion to reduced load, not emotion.

Training volume usually drops by 40 to 60 per cent, and training time usually reduces from five hours per day to two hours per day. Energy intake should reflect that, but not dramatically. The body still needs fuel to repair. Protein remains non-negotiable. I rarely go below 1.6 to 2 grams per kilogram of body weight for most strength and mixed-sport athletes. For endurance athletes, I individualise, but recovery protein stays consistent. The goal shifts from performance support to tissue rebuilding.

Another critical shift in the off-season is hormonal recalibration. After a long competitive calendar,